FLATTERY

WHO SOCIETY WANTS TO BELIEVE IT IS

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Flattery as world-building: art gives reality a coherent, reassuring shape, turning uncertainty and contradiction into something people can believe in and live with (Cassirer).
- From ruler to nation to self: the mechanism scales up over time starting with flattering individual bodies of power (pharaohs, emperors, kings), expanding into flattering whole social orders (colonial hierarchies, national ideologies), and finally arriving at the individual flattering themselves (social media).
- Complicity: following Foucault and Bourdieu, flattering images succeed by participation since people repeat and internalize them until the constructed hierarchy feels natural, "common sense," even desirable.
- Flattery cuts both ways: the same mechanism that legitimizes oppression (Casta paintings, Socialist Realism) can also sustain dignity and identity for the powerless (Matejko's Poland, Rivera's Mexico).
- Today, we no longer only consume flattering images, we produce them ourselves.

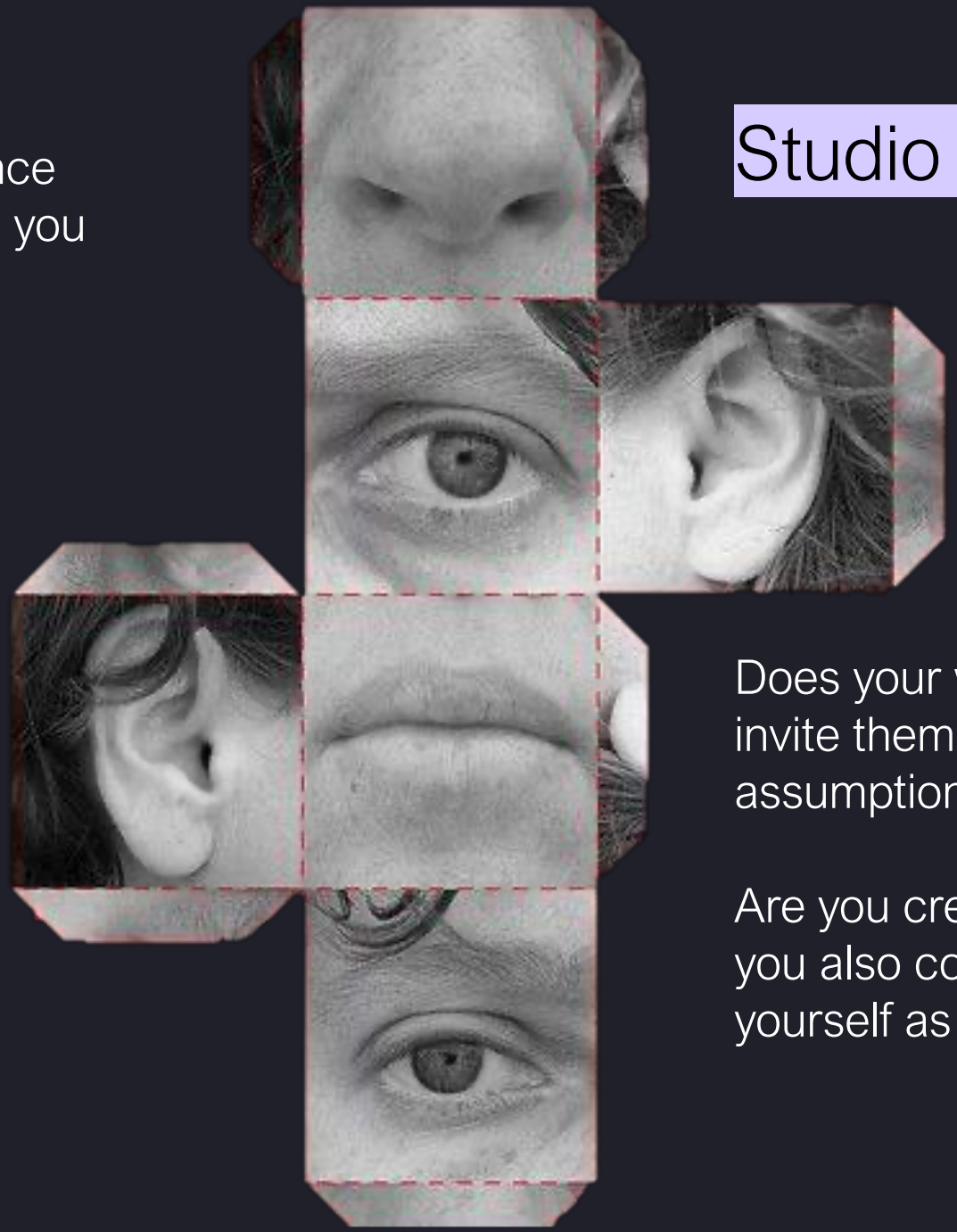
Key strategies across the examples

- The body politic vs. the mortal body (Hatshepsut, Augustus, Holbein's Henry VIII, Elizabeth's "Mask of Youth")
- Staged harmony as legitimacy (David's Napoleon)
- Taxonomy as reassurance (Casta paintings)
- Retouching history itself (Socialist Realism)
- Selective everyday life as universal ideal (Rockwell)
- Painting as national memory (Matejko)
- Replacing the hero (Rivera)
- Self-insertion as borrowed authority (Morimura)
- Self-performance as algorithmic flattery (Ulman)

Studio Reflections

What external values, expectations, or norms influence your artistic practice? How do you experience their presence?

Which values does your work reinforce? Which ones does it challenge?



Does your work reassure the viewer or invite them to question their assumptions?

Are you creating only an artwork, or are you also constructing an identity for yourself as an artist?

DIAGNOSIS

WHAT SOCIETY CANNOT ADMIT ABOUT ITSELF

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Art moves through three depths of inquiry — first reading symptoms society displays (folly, denial, spectacle), then exposing the structures that produce them (institutions, economics, power), then revealing how those structures become internalized as identity (habits, gestures, self-perception).
- Symptom level: Bruegel, Hogarth, Ensor, and Posada show that societies reveal their unconscious truths (vanity, decay, illusion, pretense) most clearly through ordinary people, crowds, and objects rather than idealized heroes.
- Structure level: Meireles, Ukeles race those symptoms back to hidden systems (state propaganda, undervalued labor, institutional authority) showing how power makes itself feel natural and invisible.
- Subject level: Attia, Spence, and Bruguera show that power gets absorbed into bodies, memory, and behavior, until the personal and political become indistinguishable.

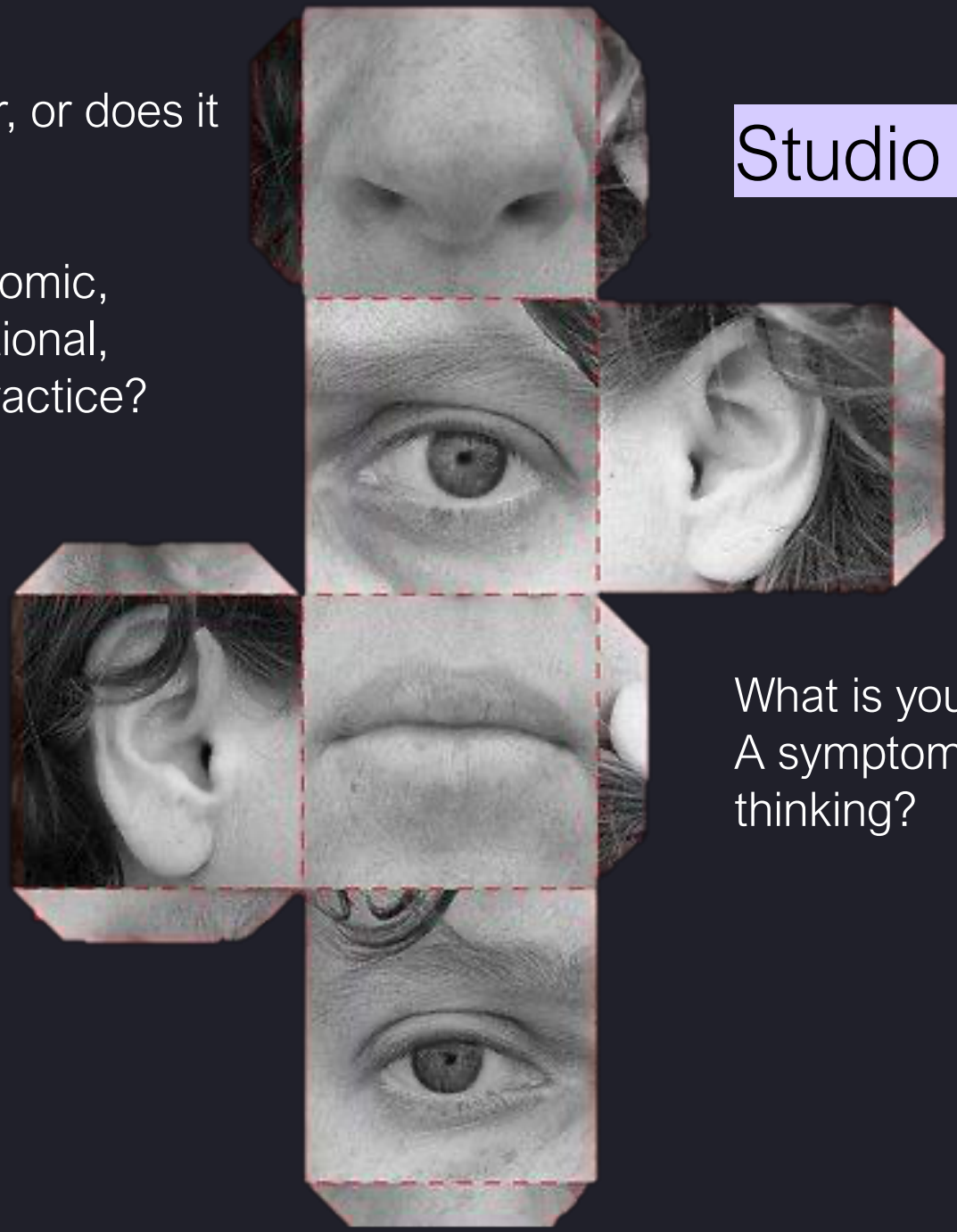
Key strategies across the examples

- The crowd and proverbs as mirror (Bruegel)
- Narrative sequence as moral pathology (Hogarth)
- The mask as revelation (Ensor)
- The skeleton as satire (Posada)
- Currency and commodity as critique
- Labor made visible (Ukeles)
- Wound and repair as memory (Attia)
- The patient's body as battleground (Spence)
- Enacted freedom as exposure (Bruguera)

Studio Reflections

Does your work expose power, or does it unintentionally reproduce it?

Which invisible systems (economic, political, technological, institutional, cultural) shape your artistic practice?



What is your work diagnosing?
A symptom, a system, or a way of thinking?

STAGING

CREATING THE CONDITIONS UNDER WHICH SOCIETY REVEALS ITSELF

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- From object to situation: the artwork stops being something you look at and becomes something you enter — a set of conditions (a meal, a payment, a reenactment, a street action) that lets society reveal or produce itself through real participation.
- Strategies like Sierra's payments, Hirschhorn's cheap materials, and El Siluetazo's actual bodies work because they use real economic, physical, and emotional relationships rather than representations of them (the contract, the site, the trace all carry literal consequence).
- The public becomes the material: whether it's Tiravanija's shared meals, Rimini Protokoll's non-actor citizens, or Deller's actual former miners and police, the artists stage real people and their differences as the content of the work itself.
- Process over product: across every example, what matters is the event (the participation, the collective action, the lived encounter). Meaning is generated in real time and can't be separated from the doing.

Key strategies across the examples

- Shared experience as medium (Tiravanija)
- Money as material (Sierra)
- The population as performer (Rimini Protokoll)
- Site as philosophy (Hirschhorn)
- Collective absence made visible (El Siluetazo)
- Reenactment as unresolved history (Deller)

Studio Reflections

What kinds of encounters does your work make possible?

What kinds of conversations, behaviors, or relationships does your work provoke?



What rules or constraints could you introduce that would reveal something unexpected about human behavior?

FINAL TAKEAWAYS

- Across history, art has related to society in three distinct ways: flattering it (constructing the image a society wants to believe about itself), diagnosing it (exposing symptoms, structures, and internalized power it cannot admit to), and eliciting it (staging real conditions in which society reveals or produces itself live).

- Flattery is a mechanism that gives reality a coherent, bearable shape, softening uncertainty into belief. The same mechanism can oppress or sustain dignity. The flattery's danger lies in **how naturalized and self-sustaining it becomes.**

FINAL TAKEAWAYS

- Diagnostic art works in three depths: it reads symptoms society displays, exposes the structures producing them, and reveals how those structures become internalized as identity and behavior.

- Contemporary artists increasingly abandon representation, staging real conditions so that society would reveal itself. Here the artwork's power comes from stakes being real: real money (Sierra), real bodies (El Siluetazo), real citizens (Rimini Protokoll), real trauma reactivated (Deller).